

Wisdom Is Justified by Her Works

Matthew 11:16–19 and the Failure of a Moving Standard

By James J. Burke

The accusations were opposites, but the verdict never changed. John’s restraint was treated as evidence of demonic influence; Jesus’ fellowship was treated as evidence of moral excess. Apparently, the acceptable place lay somewhere between them—yet it moved whenever either man approached it. That is not discernment. It is a standard designed to preserve nonresponse.

Jesus answers the generation with one of the New Testament’s most revealing uses of *justify*: “Wisdom is justified of her children” (Matthew 11:19). A well-attested textual reading has “by her works.”¹ Neither reading describes Wisdom becoming morally better. Wisdom is challenged, judged, and then shown to be right by what proceeds from her.

The saying provides an unusually clear view of justification. It shows us what happens when the subject is already right, the public verdict is wrong, and the evidence reveals the actual relation.

A Generation That Would Not Answer

But whereunto shall I liken this generation? It is like unto children sitting in the markets, and calling unto their fellows,

And saying, We have piped unto you, and ye have not danced; we have mourned unto you, and ye have not lamented.

For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, He hath a devil.

The Son of man came eating and drinking, and they say, Behold a man gluttonous, and a winebibber, a friend of publicans and sinners. But wisdom is justified of her children.

—Matthew 11:16–19

The marketplace scene contains two invitations: music suited to rejoicing and mourning suited to grief. Whether we identify John and Jesus with the callers or see the generation complaining that neither messenger followed its chosen tune, Jesus’ application is unmistakable. John and Jesus came in sharply different manners, and the generation found grounds to reject them both.

John’s ministry carried the severity of repentance. He lived in the wilderness, fasted, and warned that judgment was near. Jesus entered towns, received invitations, ate with publicans and sinners, and announced the arrival of the kingdom. John’s conduct was appropriate to preparation; Jesus’ conduct was appropriate to arrival. Mourning and rejoicing were not competing programs. Each belonged to its proper occasion within the one purpose of God.

The generation refused that purpose. John’s separation from ordinary social life was too severe; Jesus’ presence among sinners was too free. If John abstained, abstinence became suspicious. If Jesus ate, participation became sinful. The standard was not discovered and then applied. It was redrawn around the desired verdict.

“This generation” does more than identify the people who happened to be alive when Jesus spoke. Biblical generation-language is covenantal, genealogical, and moral: a generation is a people proceeding from a common source,

sharing a common character, and continuing a recognizable posture.² Jesus confronts first-century hearers, but He identifies them as present representatives of a much older lineage of rebellion. Israel had repeatedly resisted the messengers God sent; these hearers reproduce the family resemblance.

They are not irreligious people without moral categories. Drunkenness is wrong. Gluttony is wrong. Demonic influence is real. The generation uses legitimate categories while assuming illegitimate authority over their application. Like a rebel government that preserves many of the rightful king's laws, it can mirror the true order closely and still remain out of alignment because its judgment proceeds from the wrong source.

Its verdict cannot determine where Wisdom stands; it reveals where the generation stands in relation to Wisdom.

Children or Works?

Readers of the King James Version encounter the familiar conclusion, “Wisdom is justified of her children.” The form of the Textus Receptus reflected in the KJV reads:

Καὶ ἐδικαιώθη ἡ σοφία ἀπὸ τῶν τέκνων αὐτῆς.

And Wisdom was justified by her children.

Many modern editions of the Greek New Testament instead read:

Καὶ ἐδικαιώθη ἡ σοφία ἀπὸ τῶν ἔργων αὐτῆς.

And Wisdom was justified by her works.

The difference matters. “Children” points toward persons who proceed from Wisdom and bear her character; “works” points toward deeds or results produced by Wisdom. Luke’s parallel has “Wisdom is justified of all her children” without the same textual uncertainty (Luke 7:35).

The two readings are not identical, but both preserve the central relation. Wisdom is known through what proceeds from her. Her children or works do not donate rightness to their source; they manifest its character. One reading presents living offspring, the other visible effects. Either way, the evidence moves from what Wisdom produces back toward what Wisdom is.

This article will therefore use “works” except when quoting the KJV. The interpretation does not require us to flatten the textual difference. Both readings share the structure important here: the nature of the source is disclosed by what comes from it.

Who Is Wisdom?

Wisdom speaks as a woman throughout the Old Testament. She cries in the streets, summons the simple, builds her house, prepares her table, and invites people to walk in the way of understanding (Proverbs 1:20–33; 8:1–36; 9:1–6). The feminine language follows the gender of the biblical nouns; it does not introduce another divine person. Wisdom is God’s own understanding and purpose presented as a speaker and actor.³

Matthew draws upon the same personification. God’s Wisdom has acted, and the results can be examined. Jesus is not appealing to a philosophical abstraction but to the wise purpose of God taking visible form in history.

That purpose encompasses both John and Jesus. John withdrew into the wilderness, fasting and warning of the axe and the coming fire. Jesus entered homes, ate at tables, announced that the kingdom had drawn near, and received those who

came to Him. Their conduct differed because their callings differed. John prepared the way; Jesus was the One whose way had been prepared.

The generation treated those differences as contradictions. If abstinence were right, Jesus must be wrong; if fellowship were right, John must be wrong. Yet each ministry corresponded to the purpose it was appointed to serve. Israel was summoned to repentance in preparation for the King, and then the King arrived and called the lost to His table. Mourning and dancing are not incompatible when each belongs to its proper occasion.

Wisdom, then, is more than a second name casually substituted for Jesus. The saying gathers the ministries of John and Jesus into the wise ordering of God, yet Matthew draws Jesus into a relationship with Wisdom that goes beyond that of an ordinary servant. John hears of “the works of Christ” in verse 2; Wisdom is justified “by her works” in verse 19. John participates in the wise purpose of God, but the deeds most visibly disclosing that Wisdom are performed by Jesus.

The verses that follow deepen the connection. Jesus speaks of the Father hiding these things from the wise and prudent while revealing them unto babes. He then claims a unique knowledge of the Father and invites the weary to come to Him and learn from Him (Matthew 11:25–30). Wisdom once called people to receive her instruction; Jesus calls them to Himself.

God’s wise purpose governs both ministries, but in Jesus that Wisdom becomes uniquely visible. John serves Wisdom’s design; Jesus embodies it, reveals the Father, and summons people to Himself.

The generation evaluates John and Jesus as isolated religious figures whose styles can be judged according to preference. Wisdom places both within a larger order, where their differences become evidence of fittingness rather than inconsistency. The question is not whether John behaved like Jesus or Jesus behaved like John, but whether each stood where God had placed him and fulfilled the work assigned to him.

The Works That Justify Wisdom

John’s question establishes what the works must prove. He does not ask whether Jesus is admirable, compassionate, or morally upright. He asks whether Jesus is properly identified:

Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?

—Matthew 11:3

Jesus answers by pointing to what He is doing:

Go and shew John again those things which ye do hear and see: The blind receive their sight, and the lame walk, the lepers are cleansed, and the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, and the poor have the gospel preached to them.

—Matthew 11:4–5

These works do not make Jesus the Christ; they reveal that He is the Christ. Blind eyes opened, deaf ears unstopped, the lame leaping, and good tidings preached to the poor correspond to what the prophets had promised (Isaiah 29:18–19; 35:5–6; 61:1). Jesus directs John to compare what is happening before him with the standard already given in Scripture. The prophetic word established the place; the works show Jesus standing in it.

So the works justify Wisdom without conferring rightness upon her. What Wisdom produces corresponds to what God promised, to the need of those receiving it, and to the identity of the One through whom it comes.

The evidence that answers John does not persuade the generation. Jesus has acted openly, and His works can be heard, seen, and compared with the prophets. Insufficient evidence is not the problem. The generation has assumed authority to

assign the proper place for itself, and no messenger who challenges that authority will be allowed to occupy it.

Matthew then tells us what happened in the cities where Jesus performed most of His mighty works:

Then began he to upbraid the cities wherein most of his mighty works were done, because they repented not.

—Matthew 11:20

The mighty works were present; repentance was absent. Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum received more revelation than Tyre, Sidon, and Sodom, and Jesus measures their responsibility accordingly. More evidence could not create a favorable verdict when the verdict was not governed by evidence.

Their unbelief does not leave Wisdom unjustified; it leaves the cities without excuse. Her justification does not depend upon the generation's surrender. The evidence establishes her correspondence to God's standard, while the opposing verdict reveals the misalignment of those who pronounce it. The generation judges John, Jesus, and the Wisdom ordering their ministries; the works return judgment upon the generation.

What “Was Justified” Means Here

Matthew's clause is brief:

Καὶ ἐδικαιώθη ἡ σοφία ἀπὸ τῶν ἔργων αὐτῆς.

And Wisdom was justified by her works.

The verb *ἐδικαιώθη* is an aorist passive form of *δικαιόω*.⁴ Wisdom is the subject, but she is not performing the action: she “was justified.” Nothing in the form suggests that Wisdom changed inwardly, acquired a moral quality, or became something she had not previously been.

Nor would such a meaning make sense. God's Wisdom was neither deficient before the works appeared nor guilty and in need of pardon. The question is whether her rightness can be recognized in the face of the generation's accusations.

English translations therefore often use *vindicated*. Wisdom has been challenged, and the evidence answers the challenge. Yet *vindicated* is a contextual explanation of *justified*, not a replacement definition for *δικαιόω*. The verb still concerns the subject's relation to what is right. Vindication is what justification looks like when the subject was already right but has been judged wrongly.

The passive construction leaves the judging party unstated. The generation certainly does not reverse its verdict. Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum remain unrepentant. Wisdom is not justified because her opponents finally concede the argument. Her works furnish the evidence from which her rightness may be known.

Matthew expresses that relation with *ἀπό*: Wisdom is justified “from,” or idiomatically “by,” her works. The preposition points to that from which the favorable judgment arises. Her works neither transfer righteousness to her from outside nor create her correspondence to God's purpose. They make that correspondence visible.

Wisdom is God's own purpose and therefore right; her works disclose rather than cause that rightness. Each proceeds from Wisdom and bears the character of its source.

The reading “children” pictures the same movement through personal offspring. Children bear the marks of their origin just as fruit manifests the tree from which it grows. What proceeds from Wisdom reveals her; it does not donate rightness to her.

Simon Gathercole has proposed a markedly different reading: “Wisdom has been absolved of her deeds.”⁵ On his interpretation, Jesus complains that the generation has dissociated Wisdom from the ministries of John and Jesus. He takes *ἀπό* in a separative sense rather than as introducing the evidence of vindication. The proposal is grammatically argued and deserves acknowledgment, but the traditional reading remains more persuasive. The positive biblical portrayal of Wisdom’s children, Matthew’s correspondence between the works of Christ and the works of Wisdom, and the movement from rejection to demonstrated rightness all favor works as vindicating evidence rather than deeds from which Wisdom is absolved.

Comparison with Luke 18 distinguishes the core meaning of justification from its result in a particular setting. The publican goes down to his house justified because his relation to God is no longer what it was when he entered the temple. Wisdom is justified without any alteration in her relation to God. What changes is not her standing, but the public manifestation of that standing in the face of a false judgment.

The common structure is standard-relative: rightness names the correspondence between a subject and whatever truly determines how that subject ought to stand. The publican is placed rightly before God rather than remaining where his sin had left him; Wisdom is shown to have stood rightly all along, regardless of where the generation attempted to place her.

We may call the action *vindication* here without turning that contextual result into the verb’s universal definition. To justify Wisdom is to establish, acknowledge, or manifest her as right in relation to the standard against which she has been judged. Her works supply the evidence because they reveal her actual correspondence to the purpose of God.

Is Wisdom Justified by Works?

Wisdom is justified “by her works.” Read apart from its setting, the sentence might appear to establish a general rule that works create right standing. Matthew says something more exact: works can reveal a relation without creating it.

Her works proceed from the right source and correspond to the right standard. They show publicly that God’s purpose, the ministries He appointed, and the results those ministries produce belong together.

The same cannot be assumed about the works of a rebel. A man living under an illegitimate authority may perform actions resembling the commands of the rightful king. He may tell the truth, care for his family, give to the poor, and maintain public order. Those acts may be good when considered as acts, but they do not relocate him into the rightful kingdom. Outward conformity to particular commands does not correct the authority from which his life proceeds.

The generation confronting Jesus could appeal to recognizable moral standards, so its accusations sounded serious. Yet it employed those real categories from a position of rebellion, using God’s standards to reject the messengers God had sent. A rebel authority often preserves many of the rightful king’s laws. Its illegitimacy is found not in complete moral inversion but in its source: it assumes the right to govern independently, even when some of its judgments resemble the judgments of the king.

So it is with this generation. It does not call repentance, restraint, mercy, and fellowship evil. It retains those categories while claiming authority to decide when and how they apply. John’s restraint is declared demonic; Jesus’ fellowship is declared sinful. The standard shifts whenever submission to God’s messenger would otherwise be required.

Wisdom’s works do not merely resemble good deeds selected from an accepted moral list. They proceed from God’s purpose, occupy their appointed place within His order, and accomplish what His Word promised. Their rightness includes their source, character, direction, and relation to the whole. They manifest an alignment already present, while the generation’s moral accusations cannot conceal an underlying misalignment.

Matthew 11 is not answering the question, “How can an ungodly sinner be placed right with God?” It answers the accusation that God’s way through John and Jesus is wrong. Wisdom is not a sinner seeking entrance into God’s order; she is God’s own wise purpose, rejected by those who stand outside its alignment.

Making “by her works” a universal formula for how every subject is justified would flatten the passage. Works may disclose their source, demonstrate correspondence to an established standard, or expose a false accusation. Their mere existence cannot supply a person with a new source or rightful standing.

But Matthew’s language should not be weakened to protect a theological formula. The text truly says that Wisdom is justified by her works. They are the evidence from which the verdict arises, demonstrating that the accusations are false and her place within God’s order is right.

Manifestation is not relocation. Wisdom needs no relocation; her works reveal where she has always stood. The sinner needs more than evidence of occasional outward correspondence. He must be removed from the rebel order and placed under the rightful King. Works can show where someone stands; they cannot, by themselves, move him there.

When the Standard Judges the Judges

Matthew 11 places *justify* outside the usual question of a sinner’s salvation. No guilt is removed from Wisdom, no righteousness transferred to her, no inward condition changed. Her true relation to God’s purpose is manifested against the generation’s false verdict.

We therefore cannot define *δικαίωω* by one theological result. It may describe a sinner being placed right with God or God being acknowledged as right; here Wisdom is shown to have been right all along. The results differ, but the measured-against relation remains. A standard always governs the verdict.

The generation presumes that its judgment establishes reality. It assigns John the place of a demoniac and Jesus the place of a glutton and winebibber. Neither man belongs there. Wisdom’s works expose the error: John fulfills his appointed calling, and Jesus performs the works promised of the coming Christ. What looks contradictory under the generation’s shifting preferences proves harmonious when measured by God’s purpose.

Judgment returns upon the judges. The generation imagines that John, Jesus, and Wisdom stand before its court; the works reveal that the court itself has no rightful jurisdiction. It has borrowed moral language from the legitimate King while reserving judgment to a rival authority. Its verdict tells us nothing true about Wisdom’s position; it tells us where the generation stands.

Wisdom can therefore be justified while remaining rejected. Rightness is not created by consensus or the pronouncement of a court. It consists in actual correspondence to the true standard. A verdict may recognize that correspondence and evidence may display it; neither produces it.

What proceeds from a source bears its character. Wisdom’s works reveal Wisdom; the generation’s accusations reveal the generation. “Wisdom is justified by her works” means that what Wisdom produces demonstrates her proper correspondence to God’s character, promise, and purpose. This form of justification is aptly called vindication: not the donation of a fictional status or the transformation of the subject, but the manifestation of a real relation against a false judgment.

The generation attempted to move Wisdom by changing the standard. Her works revealed that Wisdom had never moved at all.

Notes

1. The form of the Textus Receptus reconstructed by F. H. A. Scrivener reads ἀπὸ τῶν τέκνων αὐτῆς (“by her children”) in Matthew 11:19. The SBL Greek New Testament and the Nestle-Aland 28th edition read ἀπὸ τῶν ἔργων αὐτῆς (“by her works”). Luke 7:35 reads ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν τέκνων αὐτῆς (“by all her children”). See F. H. A. Scrivener, ed., *The New Testament in the Original Greek according to the Text Followed in the Authorised Version* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1894); Michael W. Holmes, ed., *The Greek New Testament: SBL Edition* (Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature, 2010); and Barbara Aland et al., eds., *Novum Testamentum Graece*, 28th rev. ed. (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2012).
2. For the fuller lexical and biblical argument that “generation” may identify a covenantal, genealogical, and moral lineage rather than merely a chronological cohort, see James J. Burke, “What Did Jesus Mean by ‘This Generation’?”, *Fireproof Studies*.
3. On Matthew’s Wisdom motifs, the relation between “the works of Christ” in Matthew 11:2 and Wisdom’s works in 11:19, and the identification of Jesus with divine Wisdom, see Francois P. Viljoen, “Jesus as the Personification of God’s Wisdom in Matthew,” *In die Skriflig* 58, no. 1 (2024), article a3027.
4. On δικαίω, including its use for declaring, recognizing, or demonstrating someone to be right, and on the semantic range of ἀπό, see Frederick William Danker, ed., *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature*, 3rd ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), s.vv. “δικαίω,” “ἀπό.”
5. Simon J. Gathercole, “The Justification of Wisdom (Matt 11.19b/Luke 7.35),” *New Testament Studies* 49, no. 4 (2003): 476–488.